

The Course Companion Framework

Syllabus-aligned practice apps for gateway courses — live now for ENG 119 and ENG 120 at WCCCD

The idea

Gateway English courses are among the strongest predictors of persistence and completion — and the courses where students most need structured, repeated practice. The Course Companion is a free study app built directly from the instructor's own syllabus: every quiz, paper, and deadline is mapped to interactive lessons, drills, rewrite workshops, and a week-by-week semester map. Students get 24/7 guided practice on their phone, tablet, or computer; instructors change nothing about how they teach.

What exists today

Two live applications: **the ENG 119 Companion** (English 1, Summer 2026) and **the ENG 120 Companion** (English 2, Summer 2026), each aligned to its section's official syllabus — weekly test prep, essay and research-paper coaching, daily spaced-repetition warm-ups, mastery tracking, and a condensed syllabus in which every week links to the module that preps it. Each app is a single self-contained file served free from the web; no installation, no login, and it keeps working offline.

Why this design fits a community college

- **Academic-integrity-safe by design.** Both pilot courses ban AI tools on submitted work. The companion respects that policy structurally: it is practice-only and cannot write a student's paper.
- **Zero infrastructure, zero data risk.** No servers, no accounts, no student data collected — progress lives on the student's own device. Nothing to secure, no FERPA exposure, and hosting is free.
- **Built by AI, not run on AI.** AI does the expensive work once, at development time. Nothing generative runs while students study — no hallucinated answers in front of learners, and no per-use cost to the college.
- **Faculty stay in control.** All content derives from the instructor's syllabus, and the app tells students at every turn that the official documents and Blackboard govern.

The platform claim

The engine — lessons, drills, workshops, mastery scoring, gamification, syllabus mapping — is course-agnostic. The ENG 120 app was produced from the ENG 119 engine by swapping course content and visual identity: proof that the architecture is reusable. Standing up a companion for a new gateway course (College Algebra, Intro Psychology, Anatomy & Physiology) is roughly a week of content work, not a software project.

Roadmap

- **Phase 1 — done:** ENG 119 and ENG 120 companions live for Summer 2026 sections.
- **Phase 2 — faculty adoption:** instructor review-and-approval workflow (see next page), pilot with enrolled sections, expanded question pools, and a WCAG / Section 508 accessibility pass.
- **Phase 3 — insight:** opt-in, aggregate instructor dashboards showing where practice stalls — the one phase that adds hosting, sequenced after a formal privacy review.
- **Phase 4 — scale:** extend across the district's gateway courses, one syllabus at a time, with Blackboard-embedded delivery.

Faculty Adoption & Governance

The concerns instructors — especially adjunct faculty — will raise, considered in advance

Adoption succeeds or fails with the faculty delivering these courses, most of whom are adjuncts teaching on per-course contracts. Their likely objections are legitimate, and the framework is designed so that each has a concrete answer. The organizing principle: **the instructor is the editor-in-chief of their section's companion** — nothing carries their name without their review, and keeping the app current costs them a five-minute email, not unpaid labor. Each answer below is consistent with the draft WCCCD AI Adoption Framework: the same build standards, risk tiers, and course-level syllabus guidance (Sections 5, 7.3, and 9).

Area	The likely faculty concern	How the framework answers it
Instructor authority	"My name, my policies, and my course are in an app I never approved. If it misstates a deadline, I field the fallout."	Opt-in by design: no section goes live without instructor sign-off. A printable review copy of every lesson, drill, and answer lets an instructor vet the full app in ~30 minutes. Two tiers — "unofficial study aid" vs. "instructor-reviewed" — with the instructor's name appearing only at the level they approve.
Currency	"My schedule is tentative and changes weekly through Blackboard. A static app is out of date by Week 2 — and students will say 'but the app said.'"	A named update channel with a committed turnaround (a schedule change is a five-minute email, not a software project), a visible "aligned to syllabus dated ____" stamp in the app, and standing in-app language that Blackboard and the official syllabus always govern.
Interpretation & rubrics	"Literature is contested. The app tells students what a story's climax or theme is — and its practice scoring rubric isn't my grading rubric. Students will think a 95 in the app predicts an A from me."	Interpretation-sensitive content is phrased as a reading, not the reading, and is editable at instructor request. Practice scores are explicitly labeled as practice; rubric language can be aligned to — or hidden in favor of — the instructor's own criteria.
Academic integrity	"Could students submit the app's model paragraphs? Does drill content leak my assessments?"	All content is original practice material distinct from course assessments; model passages are short and tied to invented prompts, unusable as submissions. The app contains no generative AI and cannot write student work — structurally compliant with the courses' own AI bans.
Workload	"Adjuncts are paid per course. Anything that creates support questions or monitoring duties is unpaid work."	The instructor's total obligation is one review pass and optional change-request emails. There is nothing to administer, no accounts to manage, and no dashboard to check. Optional student-generated practice reports exist only if an instructor wants them for participation credit.
Equity & access	"What about students without reliable devices, or students using screen readers?"	The app is a single free file that runs offline on any phone, tablet, or computer — no login, no data plan dependency after first load. A WCAG / Section 508 accessibility pass is scheduled in Phase 2, before any district-level adoption.
Data & privacy	"What student data does this collect, and who sees it?"	None. Progress is stored only on the student's own device. No accounts, no tracking, no FERPA-covered records. Any future analytics (Phase 3) would be opt-in, aggregate, and precede a formal privacy review.
Role of faculty	"Is this a step toward replacing instruction?"	The companion teaches nothing on its own authority — every module points students back to the assigned reading, the instructor, and the classroom. It is a practice field attached to their

		course, not a course.
--	--	-----------------------

What Academic Affairs would need to decide

- **Endorsement policy:** whether companions may reference a section and instructor by name, and under what approval process.
- **Ownership and branding:** use of WCCCD's name, treatment of syllabus content as source material, and where the apps are hosted (external pages now; Blackboard embedding recommended at scale).
- **Compensation for review:** whether the instructor review pass is recognized (stipend, service credit, or professional development), particularly for adjunct faculty.
- **Accessibility timeline:** Section 508 conformance becomes mandatory at district adoption; the Phase 2 pass should precede any official rollout.
- **Evaluation design:** what success looks like for the pilot — usage, pass rates, persistence into the next course — measured without collecting individual student data.